

OPENING A COMMODITIES ACCOUNT

I'D HARDLY SETTLED IN CHICAGO BEFORE I ARRANGED WITH MR. Epstein to open a commodity account. This was normally accomplished by calling the 800 number or walking into the numerous brokerage houses found along the streets, but Mr. Epstein took a personal interest in my case and agreed to walk me through the paperwork in the sales department on a floor above his office.

The sales department was abuzz with cold callers, prospecting for clients from their desks, using some of the quotations I recognized from Merrill Lynch. In passing, I heard the following snippets of conversation: "I'm calling for somebody," "You told me to call you back in May," "It's up three-tenths of a cent," "What markets might you be interested in?" and "We're the largest discount commodities broker in the world."

Mr. Epstein sat me down at a long table and handed me several booklets that explained the futures markets, plus an application and some other legal papers. As I reviewed this material, he paced behind me. Apparently, the government had added to the burden of paperwork, which is why he kept mumbling, "Government, government, government." To me, the paperwork seemed minimal. I had to fill out my name, address, and estimated net worth—no more than they ask on an application for a check-cashing card at a supermarket. Then I had to sign two forms stating that I understood I could lose more money than I started with, that I could be wiped out, reduced to penury, subjected to "margin calls" and other unlikely disasters that, if taken seriously, would discourage anyone from trading futures, just as the thought of actually having to inflate a life vest would keep us all from flying.